

VELA THE SAILS

VELA IS A MAJOR SOUTHERN CONSTELLATION, FORMERLY PART OF THE LARGER ANCIENT GREEK CONSTELLATION OF ARGO NAVIS, THE SHIP. LYING IN A RICH PART OF THE MILKY WAY, VELA CONTAINS THE REMAINS OF A STAR THAT EXPLODED AS A SUPERNOVA ABOUT 11,000 YEARS AGO.

Vela represents the sails of the mythical ship *Argo*, the vessel of Jason and the Argonauts. The ancient Greeks visualized the ship as a single huge constellation, but the French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille divided it into three smaller parts in the 1750s. The other two sections are Carina, the hull, and Puppis, the stern. Vela contains several prominent star clusters, including IC 2391, a group of about 50 stars visible to the naked eye. Delta

and Kappa Velorum, along with Epsilon and Iota Carinae, form a shape known as the False Cross, which is sometimes mistaken for the true Southern Cross. Vela's most remarkable object is the Vela Supernova remnant. Lying about 800 light-years away, it is among the closest supernova remnants to us. Near its center lies the fast-spinning Vela pulsar, the remaining core of the star that exploded as a supernova in prehistoric times.

KEY DATA

- Size ranking 32
- Brightest stars Gamma (γ) 1.8, Delta (δ) 2.0–2.4
- Genitive Velorum
- Abbreviation Vel
- Highest in sky at 10pm February–April
- Fully visible 32°N–90°S



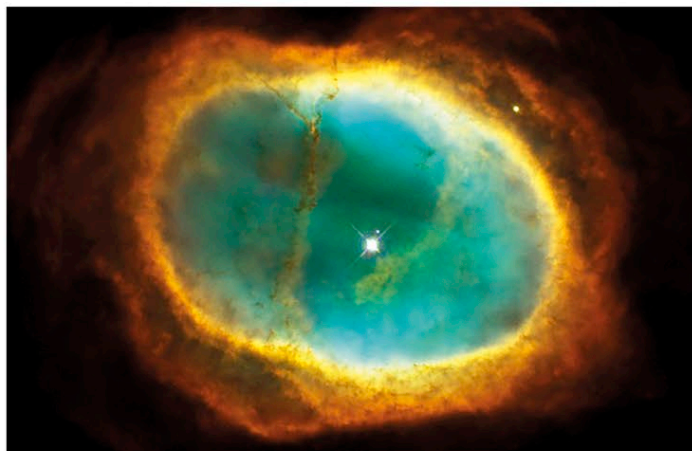
CHART 2

MAIN STARS

- Gamma (γ) Velorum**
Brightest Wolf-Rayet star visible from Earth
1.8 1,100 light-years
- Delta (δ) Velorum**
Eclipsing binary
2.0–2.4 80 light-years
- Kappa (κ) Velorum**
Blue-white subgiant or main-sequence star
2.5 570 light-years
- Lambda (λ) Velorum**
Orange supergiant
2.2 545 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

- IC 2391**
Open cluster
- NGC 2736 (Pencil Nebula)**
Part of the Vela Supernova remnant
- NGC 3132 (Eight-Burst Nebula)**
Planetary nebula, also called the Southern Ring Nebula
- NGC 3228**
Open cluster
- Vela Supernova remnant**
Supernova remnant with central pulsar



△ **Eight-Burst Nebula**
Also called NGC 3132, this planetary nebula is shaped like overlapping figure-eights, hence its popular name. Ultraviolet light from the central star has heated surrounding gas (shown as blue in this image).



▷ **Pencil Nebula**
Part of the Vela Supernova remnant, the Pencil Nebula is a region where the supernova's shock wave slammed into a denser region of interstellar gas, compressing it into the glowing strip seen in this Hubble image.



△ **Vela Supernova remnant**
This wide-field image shows the faint ribbons of gas that are the remains of a star that exploded as a supernova about 11,000 years ago. Lying between the stars Gamma (γ) and Lambda (λ) Velorum, the supernova remnant stretches across a region of sky about the width of 16 Full Moons.

The Vela pulsar rotates at more than 11 revolutions per second, faster than a spinning helicopter rotor